AI SOLUTION ARCHITECT | CONSULTATIVE & ENTERPRISE THINKING

Pre-mortem: the assistant that shipped to 600 million devices

Five questions, 30 minutes. Nothing here is marked.

Scenario: Amazon Alexa+, as it stands in public today. You are told it failed. Your job is to work out how, and who could have known first.

What a pre-mortem is, in plain words

A post-mortem asks why something died. A pre-mortem asks the same question before it has, by telling you up front that it is going to.

The trick is simple and it works because of how people talk in rooms. If you ask a group "what are the risks?", everyone hedges and you get a list of generic worries. If you tell the same group "it is eighteen months from now and this has been shut down", the question stops being about whether failure is possible and becomes about which failure. People who were being polite suddenly have permission to say the thing they were already thinking.

You are not being asked to predict the future and you will not be judged on whether you were right. A pre-mortem is judged on whether the failure path you describe is credible, and on whether the signal you name could genuinely have been seen in time.

What is the scenario?

Alexa+ is the rebuilt, generative-AI version of Amazon's voice assistant. It was announced on 26 February 2025 and became available to all US customers on 4 February 2026, after roughly a year in beta.

The pitch is not a better chatbot. The pitch is that the assistant will carry out whole tasks on your behalf inside other companies' systems: book the restaurant, order the ride, buy the tickets, hire the plumber. That is what people mean when they say agentic.

Imagine it is roughly eighteen months from now and Amazon has quietly retired it. The brand is folded away, the rollback to the older Alexa becomes permanent, and the agentic features are described as a learning experience. Nobody is fired and no scandal is involved. It simply did not work out.

The facts you are working from

All of this is public and dated. Use these numbers. Where a number you want is not here, write that it is not available rather than estimating one.

What is committed and public	The detail
Dates	Announced 26 February 2025. Early access from March 2025 on Echo Show 8, 10, 15 and 21. Generally available to all US customers on 4 February 2026.
The price	Included at no extra cost for Prime members, with unlimited access. $19.99 a month standalone for non-Prime customers. A free tier exists on the web and in the app with limits Amazon has declined to specify.

The installed base	Amazon has sold more than 600 million Alexa devices. At CES in January 2026 Daniel Rausch, VP for Alexa and Echo, said 97% of devices Amazon has ever shipped can support Alexa+.
The agentic surface	Actions run through named third parties including Ticketmaster, Uber, OpenTable, Expedia, Yelp, Thumbtack, Angi, Square, Fodor's and Suno.
The escape hatch	Customers can roll back to the older Alexa. Amazon says that option stays, but has not said for how long.
What the beta showed	Music streams up 25%, recipe engagement up five times, and two to three times more conversations per customer than with the original Alexa. Opt-out rates were described as low single digits.

What has not been shown	Why it matters here
Agentic adoption	Amazon has released no adoption numbers for the agentic features, which are the part that justifies a $19.99 price.
Task accuracy	Andy Jassy has described agentic AI tooling as still "primitive". Amazon's Nova Act accuracy has been framed as moving from roughly 30% toward 60%, with above 90% as a long-term goal.
Engagement is not completion	Every published beta win is an engagement number. More conversations and more music streams do not tell you whether a booking completed, or whether the customer had to finish it themselves.
The revenue signal	Giving the premium tier away inside Prime removes the cleanest measure of whether anyone values it. Success has to be read indirectly, from retention and Prime renewals.

Sources: TechCrunch 26 February 2025 and 4 February 2026; TechCrunch 12 January 2026 (CES remarks by Daniel Rausch); TechRadar May 2025 (Andy Jassy, earnings call); aboutamazon.com.

The request that has landed on your desk

"Write me the memo I wish someone had written before we committed."

- You cannot stop the launch. It has already happened.
- You can change exactly one decision, and it has to be a decision someone could say yes to this quarter.
- You are writing for an executive who has thirty seconds and does not want a risk register.

The outcome: what your pod actually hands back

One page. Five headings. A short paragraph under each. That is the whole artefact.

- 1. The obituary. One sentence, written from outside the company.
- 2. Five ways it died. Ranked, most likely first, with at most two technical.
- 3. The earliest signal. For your top-ranked failure only.
- 4. Who knew, and why the warning did not travel.
- 5. The one decision to change, with a named owner and a date.

Then three spoken lines, read out in the main room: the failure, the signal, the decision. Nothing else, and no fourth line.

If your memo runs past one page it has started arguing rather than deciding. Cut it, do not append to it.

How the 30 minutes runs

Time	What happens
5 minutes, silent	Everyone writes their own five failure modes alone, on paper, without talking. This is not a warm-up. If discussion starts first, the pod converges on whoever spoke first and you lose four of your five failures.
20 minutes, open	Read them out, merge the duplicates, argue about the ranking. Everyone speaks once before anyone speaks twice. The chair watches for the person who has not spoken.
5 minutes, closing	Agree the three lines you will read out. Write them down verbatim. Name who says them.

What you are being asked to produce

Five questions. Answer them in order, because each one narrows the next.

This is what you have to speak in the main room .
The resultant of your pod's analysis

1. The obituary

In one sentence, what does the failure look like from outside the company?

Answer all of these. One to four sentences in total is enough.

- Write it as a sentence a journalist would publish, not as an internal retrospective.
- Say what a Prime member actually notices on the day. A feature quietly disappearing is a valid answer.
- No internal language. If the sentence contains an internal group name, a model name or a project codename, rewrite it.

2. Five ways it died (Atleast 2 ways)

List five genuinely different failure modes, ranked most likely first. At most two may be technical.

Answer all of these. One to four sentences in total is enough.

- Five distinct mechanisms, not five descriptions of the same thing. "Accuracy was poor" and "bookings failed" are one failure, not two.
- Technical means model quality, latency, accuracy, infrastructure. You are allowed two of these at most.
- The other three live in commercial, contractual, organisational or customer territory. Think about the third parties, the price, the device base, the people who have to maintain it.
- Mark the one you would bet on. Everything after this question is about that one only.

3. The earliest signal

For your top-ranked failure, what is the first thing observable from outside the product group, roughly when, and who sees it first?

Answer all of these. One to four sentences in total is enough.

- Name something observable from outside, not something inferred. A number that moves, a complaint that repeats, a partner who goes quiet.
- Say roughly when it becomes visible, relative to the failure itself. Months before, or weeks.
- Name the role who sees it first. Not the department, the role. A support lead, a partner manager, a store operator.
- Then ask yourself the hard part: is anyone currently looking at it? A signal nobody is watching is not a signal.

4. Who knew, and why the warning did not travel

Name the role that almost certainly already knows this is a risk, then say what stopped the warning reaching someone who could act.

Answer all of these. One to four sentences in total is enough.

- Name the role. Somebody inside the organisation already has this on a slide somewhere.
- Say what blocked it. Pick a real mechanism: the metric that person is measured on, how many levels it has to climb, who would look bad, or the fact that the bad news arrives as an anecdote while the good news arrives as a dash-board.
- Do not write "poor communication" or "silos". Those are labels for the problem, not the problem.

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5. The one decision to change

One decision, changeable this quarter, with a named owner and a date.

Answer all of these. One to four sentences in total is enough.

- One. Not three, and not a programme of work.
- Name the owner by role, and a date you could put in a calendar.
- The test: could that person say yes to this on their own authority, without a new budget cycle?
- A principle is not a decision. "Be more customer-centric" fails this test. "Publish agentic task completion rate to the leadership review every month, owned by the Alexa product lead, from next quarter" passes it.

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What good looks like

On this question	A strong answer has this in it
1 · The obituary	A sentence a reasonable insider would wince at and then admit is fair. It names what the customer experiences, not what the builders got wrong.
2 · Five ways	Five different mechanisms, visibly ranked, with at least three that are not about the technology. The ranking has a reason attached, even a one-line one.

3 · The signal	Something observable before the damage, with a named role attached, and an honest note on whether anyone is currently watching it.
4 · Who knew	A named role and a specific reason the warning stalled, tied to how that person is measured or how far the message has to travel.
5 · The decision	Small, owned, dated, and inside one person's authority. Changes what gets measured or who gets told, rather than what gets built.
The three lines	Readable in under forty seconds, in the right order, with no preamble about how the pod got there.

What to avoid

- Five versions of one failure. If four of your five would be fixed by the same change, you have one failure and four symptoms.
- A test report. Five technical failures means you reviewed the product rather than the bet.
- "Users did not like it." True of every failed product and it names no mechanism. Say why.
- A signal that only appears after the damage. Cancelled subscriptions are not an early signal, they are the failure.
- A signal nobody is looking at, offered as if the looking were already happening.
- "Poor communication" or "silos" as the answer to question four. Those are the shape of the problem, not the cause.
- A decision owned by "leadership", "the business" or "us", dated "ASAP". Nobody can act on that.
- A decision that is really a principle. If it cannot be done or not done by a specific date, it is not a decision.
- Hindsight dressed as analysis. Anything that depends on knowing what happens after today is not available to you.
- A fourth line at the readout. The constraint is the exercise.

House rules

- Nothing from this session is collected, marked or submitted. The take-home is the only thing that counts.
- Use only the facts in this brief. No searching during the room.
- Where a number you want does not exist, write that it does not exist.
- Disagreement inside a pod is a finding, not a failure. If you cannot agree on the ranking, say so when you read out.
- You are reasoning about a live product in public. Keep it about the bet and the evidence, not about the people.

How to read the evidence and build your answer

“Subscriptions dropped” is not an answer. It is a symptom. Saying what happened is not the same as saying why it happened.

The discipline: you cannot just name a failure. You have to explain what caused it, and then point at something in the evidence that should have told you it was coming before anyone called it a failure.

Example of a weak answer:
"People did not buy Alexa Plus."

That is a symptom. It tells us nothing about the cause, and it names no warning sign. You could say this about any product that ever failed.

Example of a strong answer:
"People did not buy Alexa Plus because the things it charged $19.99 for, like booking a restaurant or calling an Uber, never worked reliably enough to justify paying. The evidence already hints at this: Amazon published engagement numbers like music streams up 25% and recipe use up 5x, but none of those measure whether a booking actually completed. The earliest warning sign would have been agentic task completion rate staying flat while usage numbers climbed. The decision: report completion rate for paid actions monthly, owned by the product lead, and do not renew partner contracts until that number crosses a threshold."

Notice what makes this strong: it starts from the same symptom (people did not buy it) but explains **why** (the paid features did not work reliably), ties it to **a gap already visible in the evidence** (engagement numbers that measure talking, not doing), names **an early warning sign** (completion rate flat while usage rises), and names **one decision** with an owner and a frequency.

Your answer should follow the same shape: **cause, evidence gap, early warning sign, one decision.**